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OPERATION ANADYR

On July 7, 1962, Nikita Khrushchev invited to the Kremlin a group of generals chosen to lead the Soviet deployment in Cuba. They would leave for the “island of freedom” in three days, on July 10. It was Khrushchev’s chance to give final instructions, inspire confidence, and bid farewell to those on whose actions the success of his nuclear gamble would depend.

Khrushchev was full of energy, and his rhetoric was accompanied by active gesticulation, recalled the forty-three-year-old Major General Leonid Garbuz, a deputy commander of the 43rd Missile Army headquartered in Vinnytsia, Ukraine. He had now been appointed deputy commander of the Soviet task force in Cuba. As usual, Khrushchev joked, spoke in metaphors, and told stories to convey his thoughts. “We in the Central Committee decided to toss America a ‘hedgehog’ by placing our rockets in Cuba so that America would be unable to swallow the Island of Freedom,” declared Khrushchev. He had earlier told Marshal Malinovsky, who was in attendance, that the hedgehog was supposed to go down Uncle Sam’s pants.